

The Last Warm Nights of the Year

Color, comfort, and a market that has finally stopped holding its breath.

DESIGN

Six brands named a 2027 color.
They all named the same idea.

MARKET

What 5.3 months of inventory
really means for you

HOME

Six jobs to finish before the first
cold front





FROM OUR FRONT PORCH

Neighbors. Trusted advisors. Friends.

Welcome to the very first issue of Texas Roots Living.

We built this magazine for you — our neighbors, our friends, and the corner of Texas we love most. Every month you'll find honest market numbers, the events worth leaving the house for, ideas for the home you're already in, and the occasional recipe we couldn't keep to ourselves.

Our weekly newsletter, *Texas Roots Weekly*, will keep doing what it does best — telling you what's happening this week.

GRATEFULLY,

Peter & Vicky

PETER & VICKY ROYSTER

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end. Think of *Living* as the one you keep on the counter a little longer.

Real estate has never really been about houses for us. It's about the families inside them, the streets they grow up on, and the places that make greater Houston feel like home — from the Galveston seawall all the way up to Conroe.

Thank you for letting us be part of your story. We're here whether you're planning a move or just like knowing what your house is worth.

“A neighborhood isn't the houses.
It's who waves back.”

— Vicky

*Let's keep
in touch.*

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Today, tomorrow, and every step after.

*We're building futures
through real estate.*

“

Home is where
our story begins.

THIS MONTH'S SPOTLIGHT

The Heights

Bungalows, bike trails, and the
best porch culture in Houston



LOCAL
INSIGHT.
REAL
NUMBERS.

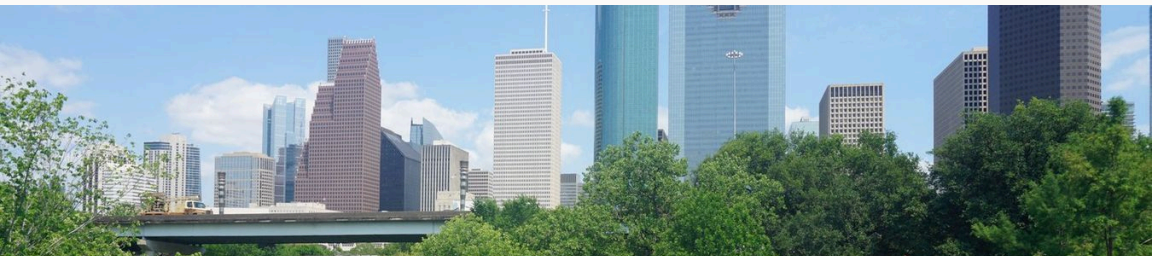
THE HOUSTON MARKET METER

A SNAPSHOT OF THE CURRENT REAL ESTATE MARKET

Greater Houston is doing something it hasn't done in years: giving both sides room to breathe. Inventory pulled back from July's record, sales cooled, and prices held nearly flat.



THE MARKET IS
BALANCED
ROOM FOR BUYERS.
EQUITY FOR SELLERS.



MEDIAN SALE PRICE \$330,000 ↓ 1.5% YEAR OVER YEAR	AVERAGE SALE PRICE \$426,760 ↑ 1.2% YEAR OVER YEAR	HOMES SOLD 7,100 ↓ 11.5% YEAR OVER YEAR
ACTIVE LISTINGS 38,947 ↑ 0.5% YEAR OVER YEAR	DAYS ON MARKET 54 ↑ from 52 LAST YEAR	MONTHS OF INVENTORY 5.3 FLAT · U.S. ~4.6

Greater Houston single-family homes. Source: Houston Association of REALTORS® Housing Market Update, August 2026 data. Information deemed reliable but not guaranteed.

MARKET HIGHLIGHTS



INVENTORY FINALLY EASED

July's record 40,750 listings finally pulled back.



SALES COOLED THE MOST ALL YEAR

7,100 closings — the sharpest drop of 2026.



PRICES HELD THEIR GROUND

Median off 1.5%, average up 1.2%. Steady, not sliding.

“

A balanced market rewards the prepared on both sides of the table.

Thinking about a move in the next year? This is the window to plan it properly — before spring compresses your timeline.

Let's talk
strategy.

SCHEDULE A FREE CONSULTATION

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THE MARKET, UPDATED

[VIEW MARKET UPDATE](#)



THE MARKET, TRANSLATED

WHAT THE NUMBERS MEAN FOR YOU

Five point three months of inventory is the most important figure in this magazine. Here is what it actually changes about your October.

BY PETER ROYSTER

MONTHS OF SUPPLY, AND WHAT EACH RANGE USUALLY MEANS



Inventory figure from HAR's August 2026 update. The four-to-six-month band is a long-standing industry rule of thumb, not an official standard.

IF YOU'RE BUYING

For four years buyers competed on speed. That is over, at least for now. With homes averaging 54 days on market, the house you like on Saturday will very likely still be there on Wednesday.

Use the time. Get the inspection you'd have waived in 2022. Negotiate on the things that quietly cost real money — closing costs, a rate buydown, a roof that has five years left in it — rather than fixating only on the number at the top of the page.

And take the option period seriously. It is the most valuable thing in a Texas contract and the one buyers most often shorten to win a bidding war they no longer have to win.

IF YOU'RE SELLING

Your house will sell. It will not sell itself, which is a different thing than it was three years ago.

Prices held nearly flat this year, so the equity is still there. But with 38,947 homes active across the metro, yours is one of a great many, and the first two weeks carry most of the traffic you will ever get. A price that is ten thousand dollars optimistic does not cost you ten thousand dollars — it costs you those two weeks, and then it costs you the ten thousand anyway.

Condition is doing real work again too. Paint, light, and a cleared-out garage move the needle more than they did when anything with a roof drew six offers.

*What we'd
do in October*

If you plan to sell in spring, start now — the work that makes a house show well takes eight weeks, and every seller in Houston has the same idea in February. If you plan to buy, get fully underwritten rather than pre-qualified. In a balanced market, the cleanest offer still wins, and it costs nothing to be the cleanest one.

*Where do
you stand?*

AN HONEST READ ON YOUR OWN HOUSE

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NO OBLIGATION

GET YOUR HOME VALUE ›



DESIGN • THE 2027 COLORS

BACK DOWN TO EARTH

Six paint brands have named a 2027 Color of the Year. Remarkably, they all named the same idea.



Cottage Door

VALSPAR • V138-4

A steely neutral blue. First out, back in August.



Deep Rooted

DUTCH BOY • 311-7DB

Earthy clay orange. The boldest of the six.



Grounded

BEHR • T27-01

Mossy olive with brown underneath it.



Artifact

GLIDDEN & PPG

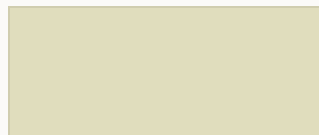
A smoky blue. Two brands, one pick.



Rose Earth

GRAHAM & BROWN

A warm neutral, after Italian clay.



Celery

SHERWIN-WILLIAMS • SW 6421

Soft yellow-green. The newest, and the palest.

Swatches are approximations. Cottage Door, Grounded and Celery are rendered from published values; the others from published descriptions. Judge any color from a real sample, never from a printed page or a screen.

Every autumn the paint companies tell us what we are supposed to want, and every autumn most of us ignore them. This year is worth a second look — not for any one color, but for how strangely unanimous they were.

Six brands, competing companies with separate research teams and no reason to agree, announced between early August and mid-September. Valspar went first with Cottage Door, a steely blue. Dutch Boy followed with Deep Rooted, an earthy clay orange, then Behr with Grounded, a mossy olive. Glidden and PPG both landed on Artifact, a smoky blue.

Graham & Brown chose Rose Earth, a warm neutral drawn from Italian clay. Sherwin-Williams closed out the run on September 15 with Celery, a soft yellow-green.

Look at the names rather than the chips. Grounded. Deep Rooted. Rose Earth. Artifact. These are not color names; they are a mood board for the same feeling — soil, moss, clay, weathered sky. Not one brand reached for a bright, and not one reached for the cool gray that dominated the last decade.

Benjamin Moore and Dunn-Edwards have not announced yet. It would be a genuine surprise if they broke the pattern.

*Thinking
about paint?*

WE'LL TELL YOU WHAT ACTUALLY PAYS BACK

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CONTINUED

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Test it on all four walls, and look at it twice — once at seven in the morning, once with the lamps on. A color that only works at noon doesn't work.

WHY A NATIONAL PICK MEANS LESS HERE

Earth tones are the most light-sensitive colors there are, and Houston light is not gentle. We get hard sun, long hot seasons, and a great deal of glare bouncing off concrete, water and pale brick.

The practical result is that none of these six will look the same in two houses ten miles apart. Under heavy tree canopy in The Woodlands, Conroe or the older streets of the Heights, filtered green light pushes the olives and the yellow-greens softer and deeper — which is where they look best. On an open lot in Katy, Cypress or Pearland, with full afternoon sun off a light driveway, the yellow in Celery comes forward and can tip toward weak chartreuse, while Grounded flattens out to something closer to army surplus.

The blues run the opposite way. Cottage Door and Artifact hold up beautifully in our glare, where they read as calm rather than cold, and go slightly flat in a dark north-facing room.

WHERE THEY EARN THEIR KEEP

These colors want something to bounce against — warm wood, unlacquered brass, limestone, natural fiber. The deeper five are very good on kitchen cabinetry, particularly a lower run beneath a white perimeter, and on a study, a laundry or a

mudroom. Celery, the palest of them, is the only one of the six that will behave as a whole-room wall color in an average Houston living room without closing it in.

WHERE WE'D SKIP THEM

Windowless interior rooms, where the olives go gray and slightly institutional. North-facing bedrooms for anything in the blue family. And any bathroom lit exclusively by cool LED, which turns all six faintly clinical.

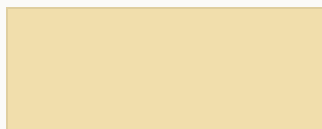
THE RESALE QUESTION, ANSWERED HONESTLY

We sell houses for a living, so let us be the ones to say it: colors of the year date themselves. This whole earthy palette will read as 2027 in about six years, the same way greige reads as 2014 right now.

That is not a reason to avoid it. It is a reason to put it where changing your mind is cheap. Paint on drywall is the cheapest decision in your house — a weekend and a hundred dollars. Cabinet paint is a little more. Tile, countertops, plumbing fixtures and roofing are not, and a trend color in any of those is how a kitchen ends up dating a whole house.

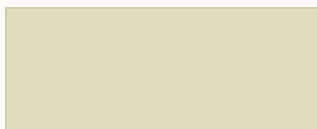
Put the trend where a roller can undo it. Keep the permanent things quiet. That rule has never once cost a seller money.

THE SAME GREEN, THREE HOUSTON ROOMS



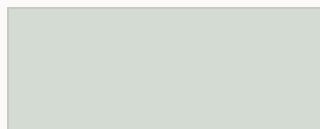
WARM AFTERNOON SUN

West-facing rooms, open lots. The yellow steps forward.



EVEN NORTH LIGHT

Celery as the fan deck shows it. Rarely how you'll see it.



SHADE UNDER OAKS

The Woodlands, Conroe, the older Heights streets. Greener.

*Before you
buy a gallon*

Two coats on a two-foot square of poster board, moved around the room for three days. Never judge one of these against a white wall — the white will make it look dirty. And check it against your floors, which you are not replacing.

HOME • FIVE MINUTES

THE FIVE-MINUTE FALL WELCOME

Your front entry is the only room in the house that greets people before you do — and the only one you can transform in the time it takes to unload the dishwasher.



01 WASH THE DOOR, NOT JUST THE PORCH

Houston humidity leaves a film on a front door that you stop seeing after about a month. Warm water, a little dish soap, and two minutes will make a five-year-old door look refinished. Do the handle and the kick plate while you're there.

02 ONE BIG PLANTER BEATS THREE SMALL ONES

Scale is the single thing separating a styled entry from a cluttered one. A pair of oversized urns flanking the door reads as intentional; five assorted pots read as whatever was on sale.

03 CHANGE THE BULB, CHANGE THE EVENING

Most porch lights ship with a cool white bulb that makes brick look gray and skin look ill. Swap it for a 2700K warm bulb. It is the cheapest upgrade in this magazine and the one people notice without knowing why.

04 RETIRE THE MAT

A doormat has a lifespan of roughly one year in this climate and almost everyone keeps theirs for four. A new one costs less than lunch and is the first thing a guest looks down at while they wait for you to answer.

05 TAKE AWAY ONE THING

The coiled hose, the recycling bin, the cobweb in the corner of the lantern, the faded flag. Removal is free and it does more than anything you could add. Stand at the end of your own walkway and look the way a stranger would.

“ This is also the first photograph a buyer ever sees of your house. Worth five minutes either way.

— Vicky

*Getting ready
to show?*

WE'LL WALK YOUR HOUSE WITH YOU

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BEFORE THE PHOTOS

BOOK A WALK-THROUGH >



HOME · SEASONAL



SMALL JOBS.
BIG SAVINGS.

OCTOBER HOME CARE

Six jobs to finish before the first real cold front — written for Gulf Coast houses, not for someone's winter in Ohio.



SERVICE THE HEAT NOW

You have run the air conditioner for seven straight months. Change the filter and get the system looked at in October, while every HVAC company in Houston still answers the phone on the first ring.



DETECTORS, WITH THE CLOCKS

When the time changes, change the batteries in every smoke and carbon monoxide detector. If yours are older than ten years, the units themselves are expired, not just the batteries.



GUTTERS, AFTER THE DROP

Our leaves come down late. Clear them once in November rather than twice in October, but check now that the downspouts actually carry water away from the foundation.



REVERSE THE FANS

Clockwise in cool weather pushes warm air back down off the ceiling instead of blowing it across you. It takes one switch on the motor housing and it genuinely changes how a room feels.



HOSES OFF, SPIGOTS COVERED

Houston freezes. Not often, and not for long, but 2021 taught everyone what a hard freeze does to an outdoor faucet with a hose still attached. Ten dollars of foam covers, one afternoon.



WEATHER-STRIP THE TWO WORST DOORS

You already know which ones. The garage door into the house and whichever exterior door you can see daylight under. Both are a twenty-minute job and both show up on the next electric bill.

THE ONE NOBODY DOES

Go find your main water shut-off valve, right now, before you need it. Not the street meter — the one at the house. Then make sure everyone who lives there knows where it is and that it actually turns.

Every plumber in this city has the same story from February 2021: the damage was rarely the burst pipe. It was the forty minutes it took a homeowner to find the valve in the dark.

A house in Houston does not fail in the cold. It fails in the one week a year we pretend we don't get any.

*Need a name
you can trust?*

OUR OWN VENDOR LIST, FREELY GIVEN

The plumbers, roofers and HVAC techs we call for our own houses. Just ask.

NO CHARGE, NO CATCH

[ASK FOR A REFERRAL >](#)



THE COVER STORY · OUTDOOR LIVING

An Outdoor Room

For about six weeks a year, the best room in a Houston house is the one without a ceiling. Here is how to build one that earns those weeks — and the eleven months around them.

A cedar ceiling, a fireplace, and a finished surface underfoot — three of the four rules, before you even reach the water.

Every Houston homeowner knows the feeling of the first cool evening. You step outside after dinner, the air has finally let go, and you think: we should be out here every night.

Then it is July again and the patio sits empty for four months.

The houses that solve this do one thing differently. They stop treating the backyard as a slab with furniture on it and start treating it as a room — with the same four things every good room has.

1. SOMETHING OVERHEAD

A room needs a ceiling. Outdoors that can be a covered porch, a pergola, a sail, or even a mature canopy of oaks, but it has to be something. Shade is what turns an unusable slab into a place you sit at four in the afternoon, and it is the single high-return thing you can add out there.

WHERE WE'D SPEND FIRST

Shade, then surface, then light — in that order. In our experience buyers notice whether they could sit outside comfortably in August far more than they notice an expensive built-in grill. A covered porch and a finished patio read as living space. A twelve-thousand-dollar outdoor kitchen usually just reads as a grill.

2. LIGHT AT EYE LEVEL

Overhead floodlights make a patio feel like a parking lot. String lights, lanterns, and a low fixture or two make it feel like a room after dark. Hang the strings lower than instinct tells you — roughly eight feet — so the light falls on faces rather than on the top of your head.

3. A REASON TO STAY WHEN IT COOLS

A fireplace, a fire table, or a simple portable heater extends the season on both ends by weeks. This is the difference between a backyard used in April and October and one used in April and October and also November, February and March.

4. EDGES

An outdoor rug and a bit of planting around the perimeter do what walls do indoors: they tell your eye where the room stops. It is a hundred-dollar trick that reads as a renovation.

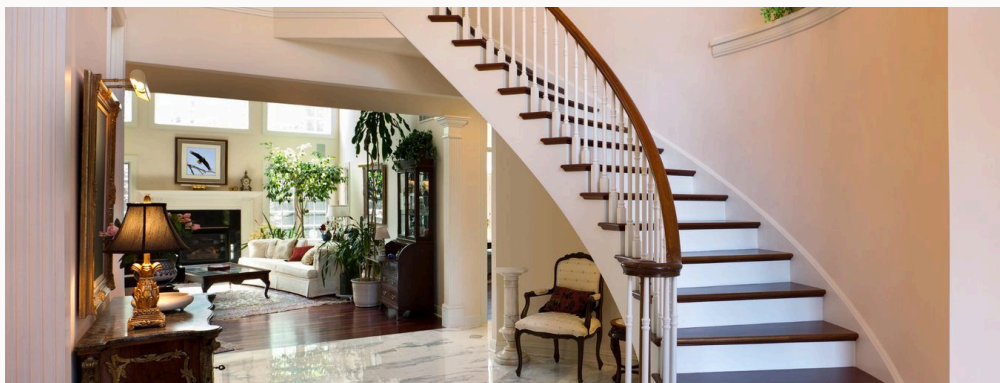
A slab with furniture on it is a patio. Give it a ceiling and an edge and it becomes a room.

— Peter

THE LONG VIEW

IS YOUR HOME STILL THE RIGHT SIZE?

Nobody downsizes because of square footage. They do it because of stairs, or a lawn, or four rooms nobody has walked into since Christmas.



The honest version of this question is not about size at all. It is about which rooms you actually live in.

Walk your own house on an ordinary Tuesday and count the rooms you entered. Most people are surprised. The formal dining room, the guest suite, the second living area, the bonus room over the garage — these were bought for a version of life that may have moved on without them.

That is not a reason to sell. Plenty of people keep the space on purpose, for the grandkids at Thanksgiving or the hope of them. But it is worth knowing what the unused half of a house actually costs: the taxes on it, the insurance on it, the cooling of it through a Houston August, and the Saturdays spent maintaining it.

THE FOUR SIGNS THAT USUALLY START THE CONVERSATION

The stairs have opinions. Not a crisis, just a knee that comments on the second floor. People tend to move about three years after they first notice.

Storage has become a strategy. When rooms are being used mainly to hold things, the house is working as a warehouse rather than a home.

The yard runs the weekend. An acre is a joy at fifty and a job at seventy, and the shift happens gradually enough that nobody marks the date.

You are cooling rooms for nobody. In this climate that is a real, monthly, measurable number.

AND THE PART THAT IS NOT ARITHMETIC

A house where a family grew up is not a spreadsheet, and we have never once had a right-sizing conversation that stayed purely financial. It usually gets quiet somewhere in the middle. That is normal, and it is not a reason to rush.

What we would say is this: make the decision while it is still yours to make, unhurried, on your own timeline. The hardest moves we help with are the ones made three months after something forced the issue.

Thinking about it?

NO PRESSURE, NO TIMELINE

We're happy to run the numbers and have you decide nothing at all. Plenty do.



MONEY • PLAINLY

THE LOAN CONVERSATION

Four questions people ask us constantly, answered without a single sales pitch.

“SHOULD I WAIT FOR RATES TO DROP?”

Nobody has ever reliably called the direction of rates, ourselves included, and anyone who tells you otherwise is guessing with confidence. What we can say is that rate and price move against each other. When borrowing gets cheaper, more buyers come back, and competition does to the price what the rate just did to your payment. Waiting is a bet, not a plan.



“PRE-QUALIFIED, PRE-APPROVED — IS THERE A DIFFERENCE?”

A large one. A pre-qualification is a conversation. A pre-approval means a lender has looked at real documents. Fully underwritten approval — where the file has already been through underwriting before you ever write an offer — is stronger still, and in a market where sellers are weighing several offers, it is the cheapest advantage available to you. It costs nothing but paperwork and a few days.

“HOW MUCH DO I ACTUALLY NEED DOWN?”

Less than most people assume. Twenty percent is a convention, not a requirement, and it exists mostly to avoid mortgage insurance. There are conventional products well below that,

VA loans with no down payment for those who qualify, and a range of Texas assistance programs that come and go. The right number depends on your situation, which is precisely why this is a conversation with a lender and not a rule you read in a magazine.

“WHO SHOULD I CALL?”

Talk to two, and make one of them local. National call centers are fine until something goes sideways at eight in the evening eleven days before closing, at which point a name and a cell phone number is worth a quarter point. We refer most of our clients to Matt Brown at Encompass Lending, including our veteran clients for VA financing, and we are glad to make the introduction — but we get nothing if you use him, and we will happily look at whatever quote you bring us from anyone else.



Bring us the estimate before you sign it. Loan estimates are standardized documents, which makes two of them genuinely comparable side by side — and we will read yours with you at no charge, whether or not we are the ones selling you a house.

*Straight
answers.*

NOTHING HERE IS FINANCIAL ADVICE

Rates, programs and terms change constantly.
Confirm current numbers with your lender.

WE'LL MAKE THE INTRO

TALK TO A LENDER ›



A QUIETER KIND OF MOVE

The House Between Us

It is usually the largest asset and always the hardest one to talk about. A calm, practical look at the three paths — and the part that is not ours to advise on.

In most Texas divorces the house is both the biggest number on the page and the only asset anyone has an actual memory of. That combination makes it the thing people decide last and worry about first.

There are really only three outcomes, and it helps enormously to know that early.

ONE OF YOU KEEPS IT

The person staying buys out the other's share, almost always by refinancing into their own name alone. Two things decide whether this is possible, and neither is negotiable: whether that person qualifies for the new loan on their income by itself, and whether there is enough equity to fund the buyout. In Texas this is often structured using an owelty lien, which is a real and routine tool — but it is drafted by the attorneys, not by us.

WHY WE HANDLE THESE DIFFERENTLY

We have been through this ourselves. That is not a credential and we would not pretend it is — but it does mean nobody here is going to rush you, and nothing you say is going to surprise us.

Both parties hear the same information at the same time. Showings are scheduled around two calendars. Nothing about the situation appears in the marketing. And if the two of you are not speaking, you will not have to — all of it can run through the attorneys.

YOU SELL AND DIVIDE THE PROCEEDS

The cleanest option, and the most common. Both names come off the debt on the same day, which matters more than people expect: a mortgage with two names on it stays a shared obligation no matter what the decree says about who pays it.

YOU WAIT

Sometimes the right answer is to hold the house for a defined period — until a school year ends, or a market improves — with the terms written down. If you choose this, get specific in the decree about who pays the mortgage, the taxes, the insurance and the repairs, and about exactly what triggers the eventual sale. Vagueness here is what brings people back to court.

WHAT WE WILL NOT DO

Give legal advice, interpret your decree, or tell you which path to take. We are REALTORS®, not attorneys. Every question in this article ultimately routes back to your lawyer and your lender — we simply make sure the real estate half is handled so it isn't one more thing to fight about.

*Confidential,
always.*

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Nothing in this article is legal advice.

A QUIET PLACE TO START

[DIVORCE GUIDE](#) ›



AT THE TABLE

FIRST COOL FRONT CHILI

Made with cubed chuck rather than ground beef, and without a single bean — which in this state is less a recipe note than a legal position.

SERVES 6 TO 8 • ABOUT 3½ HOURS, MOSTLY UNATTENDED

INGREDIENTS

3 lb beef chuck, in ½-inch cubes

2 tbsp neutral oil

1 large yellow onion, diced

4 cloves garlic, minced

2 tbsp tomato paste

3 dried ancho chiles

2 dried guajillo chiles

1 chipotle in adobo, plus

1 tsp of the sauce

2 tbsp ground cumin

1 tbsp Mexican oregano

1 tbsp masa harina

2 cups beef stock

1 bottle (12 oz) lager

1 tbsp cider vinegar

Kosher salt

TO SERVE

Diced white onion, lime wedges, crumbled cotija, and saltines. Cornbread if you must, but the saltines are correct.

1 • WAKE UP THE CHILES

Stem and seed the ancho and guajillo chiles. Toast them in a dry skillet over medium heat, about thirty seconds a side, until they smell nutty — any longer and they turn bitter, which cannot be undone. Cover with boiling water and let them sit twenty minutes. Blend smooth with one cup of the soaking liquid, the chipotle and its sauce.

2 • SEAR, AND DO IT PROPERLY

Pat the beef dry and salt it well. In a Dutch oven over medium-high heat, brown it in three batches — crowding the pan steams the meat and costs you the whole point of using chuck. Set the beef aside as it finishes.

3 • BUILD THE BASE

Lower the heat. Cook the onion in the drippings six to eight minutes until soft and golden, add the garlic for one minute more, then the tomato paste for two, stirring until it darkens a shade.

4 • THE LONG PART

Return the beef and any juices. Add the chile purée, cumin, oregano, stock and beer. Bring to a bare simmer, cover, and leave it alone for two and a half to three hours, until a cube gives way under a spoon with no resistance at all.

5 • THICKEN AND FINISH

Whisk the masa harina into a quarter cup of water and stir it in. Simmer uncovered twenty minutes. Add the vinegar — this is the step people skip and the one that makes it taste finished — then salt until it tastes like something rather than like almost something.

6 • WAIT, IF YOU CAN

It is better the next day. It is considerably better the day after that.

*Made it?
Tell us.*

SEND US A PHOTO

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We'll run the best one next month.

MORE FROM OUR KITCHEN

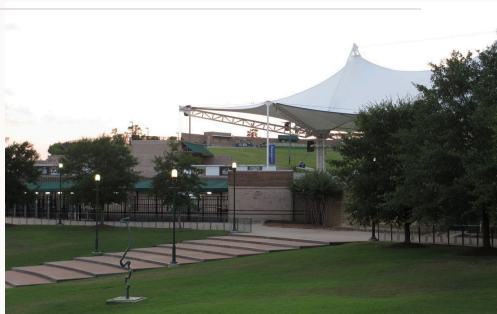
[SEE ALL RECIPES](#) ›



FIVE THINGS WORTH DOING

October, from the bay to the pines.

The weather finally turns, the festivals start, and greater Houston remembers it has an outdoors. Here's what we'd actually leave the house for this month.



WINGS OVER HOUSTON

The airshow returns to Ellington Field — warbirds, aerobatics, and a very good excuse to look up all afternoon.

OCT 2-4 • ELLINGTON FIELD



BAYOU CITY ART FESTIVAL

Memorial Park fills with original work from artists around the country, plus live stages and a food truck park.

OCT 9-11 • 10AM-6PM • MEMORIAL PARK



KOREAN FESTIVAL HOUSTON

Food, music, and dance take over Discovery Green for one very full Sunday downtown.

SUN OCT 11 • 11AM-8PM • DISCOVERY GREEN



TEXAS RENAISSANCE FESTIVAL

Its 52nd season opens in Todd Mission and runs weekends into late November. Go early, wear real shoes.

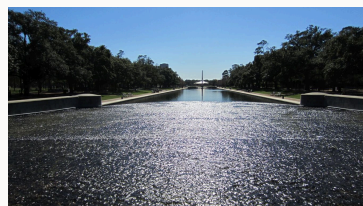
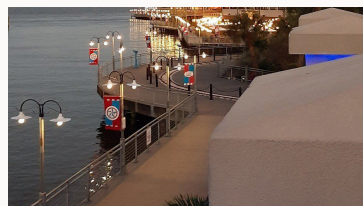
SAT & SUN, OCT 10 - NOV 29 • TODD MISSION



A COOL MORNING ON THE TRAIL

No ticket required. The first mornings under 70° are the whole reason we live here — take the Heights hike-and-bike or the Kemah boardwalk before the crowds.

ALL MONTH • ANYWHERE YOU LIKE



MARK YOUR CALENDAR

- Wings Over Houston • Oct 2-4
- Bayou City Art Fest • Oct 9-11
- Korean Festival • Oct 11
- Texas Ren Fest opens • Oct 10

“

The best thing about October in Houston is that you can finally sit outside and mean it.

— Peter

*We live here.
We love it here.*

MORE LOCAL, EVERY WEEK

Texas Roots Weekly lands each Friday
with the weekend's best.



NEIGHBORHOOD SPOTLIGHT

THE HEIGHTS

Twenty-three feet of elevation, a hundred and thirty-five years of stubbornness, and the best porch culture in Houston.



The Heights exists because of mosquitoes. In 1891 a Nebraska banker named Oscar Martin Carter bought 1,756 acres northwest of Houston and built Texas' earliest planned community on it — chosen largely because the land sat twenty-three feet higher than the city, above the flooding and the yellow fever that came with it.

It incorporated as its own city in 1896 and stayed one until Houston annexed it in 1918, and something of that independence never quite wore off. Much of the neighborhood has been legally dry since its founding, a quirk that still shapes how some restaurants there serve a glass of wine.

What draws people now is what the grid left behind: wide esplanades, deep lots, and block after block of bungalows and Victorians that were built to be sat in front of rather than merely looked at.

THE FACTS

Founded 1891

Original tract 1,756 acres

Elevation 23 ft above downtown

Own city 1896–1918

Housing Bungalows, Victorians,
new-build infill

Trail Heights Hike & Bike

WHAT TO KNOW BEFORE YOU BUY

Large parts of the Heights sit inside city historic districts, which govern what you may change about an exterior. It protects the streetscape you fell in love with — and it means a renovation plan needs checking before, not after. Ask us and we'll pull the district map for the specific block.

“It is one of the few Houston neighborhoods where the sidewalk is part of the house.”

— Peter

*Curious about
a block?*

WE'LL SEND THE REAL NUMBERS

Recent sales, historic district lines, flood zone
and tax detail for any street you name.

ANY NEIGHBORHOOD, ANY TIME

[ASK ABOUT A NEIGHBORHOOD](#) ›



HOMES WE'RE SHOWCASING

Five doors worth opening this month.

GALVESTON
TO CONROE.



FEATURED • GALVESTON

7000 Seawall Blvd #324

GALVESTON, TX • GULF-FRONT CONDO

\$230,000

Wake up to the water. A turnkey condo on the seawall with the beach across the street and the Strand ten minutes behind you.

[SEE THIS HOME >](#)

ALSO ON THE MARKET



18926 WILDROSE LN

Tomball • Acreage and room to spread out, north of the Grand Parkway.

\$999,999

[VIEW >](#)



2103 CARRIAGE RUN W

Conroe • A well-kept home on a quiet run, minutes from the lake.

\$485,000

[VIEW >](#)



12542 SABINE POINT

Humble • Move-in ready and priced to go, with easy access to 59.

\$315,000

[VIEW >](#)



183 COUNTY ROAD 436

Dayton • Raw land, wide open. Build the thing you've been sketching.

\$155,000

[VIEW >](#)

List prices current as of October 1, 2026 and subject to change. Each home links to its full page at movelivelovetx.com.



BUYING THIS FALL?

With 5.3 months of inventory on the market, you have something buyers haven't had in years: time to think, and room to negotiate.

*Your next home
starts here.*

PETER & VICKY ROYSTER

713-805-6247 • homes@movelivelovetx.com
CB&A, Realtors • The Woodlands, TX

EVERY HOME, ONE PLACE

[SEARCH AVAILABLE HOMES >](#)



SELLING

BEFORE YOU LIST

What we would actually spend money on — and the expensive projects we would talk you out of.

WORTH DOING

**PAINT, IN ONE QUIET COLOR**

The highest return of anything on this page, every time.

**LIGHT — BULBS, AND MORE OF THEM**

Matched warm bulbs throughout. Dark rooms photograph small.

**EMPTY THE GARAGE**

Buyers read a full garage as "this house has no storage."

**A PRE-LISTING INSPECTION**

Find the surprise yourself, on your schedule, with time to price it.

**PROFESSIONAL PHOTOGRAPHY**

Non-negotiable. It is the showing before the showing.



USUALLY NOT WORTH IT

A full kitchen remodel. You rarely recover it, and the buyer wanted a different quartz anyway.

A pool. In Houston it divides buyers roughly in half. Never install one to sell.

Replacing a roof with life left in it. Get it inspected, document it, and let the report do the talking.

Room-by-room upgrades. Half-renovated reads worse than honestly dated.

“

The most amazing realtor me or my family has ever dealt with... Here we are 16 days later and we are under contract. Thank you Peter, I will forever recommend and hire you for the rest of my days!

JENNIFER WESTERMAN

WHAT CLIENTS SAY

4.9 Google · 38 reviews

5.0 Zillow · 30 reviews

4.98 HAR · 88 surveys

Peter licensed since 2004, Vicky since 2020. Hundreds of transactions between them. Ratings as of September 2026.

*Listing
this spring?*

THE PREP WORK TAKES EIGHT WEEKS

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CB&A, Realtors

START EARLY, SELL BETTER

PLAN YOUR SALE >



YOU ASKED

ASK PETER & VICKY

Four questions that came up more than any others this month, answered the way we'd answer them at your kitchen table.

"DO I NEED TO FIX THE FENCE BEFORE WE LIST?"

Repair it, don't replace it. A leaning fence reads as deferred maintenance and makes buyers wonder what else was deferred. A brand-new fence, on the other hand, quietly announces that something was wrong. Straighten, replace the broken pickets, and let it look cared for rather than new.

"OUR TAX APPRAISAL CAME IN LOWER THAN WHAT YOU THINK WE'D SELL FOR. WHICH IS RIGHT?"

Both, for different purposes. An appraisal district value is a mass-produced estimate built for taxation, generated by a model that has never been inside your kitchen. Market value is what a real buyer with real financing will actually pay this month. They are frequently thousands apart in either direction, and neither one is lying.

**"SHOULD WE SELL FIRST OR BUY FIRST?"**

In this market, more often sell first — and that is the opposite of the advice we were giving in 2021. With homes sitting an average of 54 days, the risk of owning two houses at once is real, while the risk of selling and having nothing to buy has largely faded. There are bridge options and leasebacks that let you stay in your house after closing, and a leaseback is usually cheaper and less stressful than a bridge loan. Which of the two fits depends entirely on your equity and your timeline, so ask before you assume.

"IS IT RUDE TO INTERVIEW MORE THAN ONE AGENT?"

It is the opposite of rude. You are handing somebody the largest asset you own and a six-figure decision, and any agent who is offended by being compared has told you something useful for free. Interview two or three. Ask each of them what they would price it at and, more revealingly, why — then notice which one brought evidence and which one brought a number they thought you wanted to hear.

*Got a
question?*

Send it to homes@movelivelovetx.com and we'll answer it here next month — first names only, or anonymously if you'd rather. No question about your own house is too small, and we have genuinely never minded being asked.

*Real questions.
Real answers.*

PETER & VICKY ROYSTER • CB&A, REALTORS

713-805-6247 • homes@movelivelovetx.com

ASK US ANYTHING

SEND A QUESTION ›



UNTIL NEXT MONTH

Let's Write Your Story

*Whether you're moving this spring, three years from now, or simply like
knowing what your house is worth — we're here, anywhere from
Galveston to Conroe, and there's never a bill for a conversation.*

28+

YEARS COMBINED

4.9

GOOGLE RATING

2004

HELPING HOUSTON SINCE

[START A CONVERSATION >](#)

PETER & VICKY ROYSTER

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